

A COMMISSION, THRICE OFFERED

player handout — found folded three times, sealed in black wax bearing no sigil

“You were named to me three times, by three mouths, and so I write. There is a house on Museum Hill where the city keeps its memory, and in that house one small thing that is mine by an older claim than any label. Tomorrow it goes where no claim can follow. Tonight, then.”

“Six hundred gold when we speak. Nine hundred more when it rests in my hand — three hundred a head for five, half again a fair rate, because the house is careful and I am generous. Everything the work requires has already been bought and paid for; you will simply be collecting it. Come to the revel beneath the Old Harbor when the drums start. Wear a mask. Bring a truth you can bear to say aloud — the door charges one.”

“My circle asks three things. Kill no one. Be seen taking nothing. And whatever you find at the heart of that house — do not touch it with your skin. — T.”

What any citizen of Aetherion knows

- **The Aletheion** is the Imperial Mouseion on Museum Hill — the empire's own history in five rooms: the founders' relics, the war hall of the Storm-Star, a gallery about the violet sky, and a bronze vault of things dug out of the old ruins. Entry 2 sp, open till dusk.
- Its star exhibit is a **key of bronze and bone**, raised from a dead kingdom's ruins and kept behind a mirrored Academy seal no one is allowed to approach. The morning after tomorrow's grand anniversary exhibition, the Academy takes it away for good.
- Tonight the museum is **closed for re-labeling**. Lamps burn late. Clerks and caterers come and go by the service dock.

What the street says (believe what you like)

- The night warden plays dice badly and owes worse people.
- The bronze statues in the rotunda are never quite where they were yesterday.
- Someone in grey vestments has been working upstairs all week, and the staff won't say who.
- There's an old rain-cistern under Museum Hill, from before the museum was built.
- The vault floor is cursed glyphs that melt the boots off a liar.
- The key screams if you touch it. That's why the seal.

What to bring

A mask for the revel. A truth for the door. Rope, dark clothes, quick fingers, and a plan for getting out that is better than your plan for getting in.

The pay: 600 gp on meeting, 900 gp on delivery — split five ways however you please.